



FIGURE 4.10 James Gillray, *High Change in Bond Street; ou la politesse du grande monde* [graphic]. Etching on wove paper, hand-colored.

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meant to bewilder the viewer. Satins, silks, ivory, gigantic eggs, and “artificial” apples describe, in fact, the things of the trade: expensive and rare fabrics, on the one hand, strange collectibles and exotica, on the other. Lavish dresses and embellishments become insignia of wealth, power, and nonconformity, of a way of life outside the economic constraints of the Western civilization. Interestingly, such projections were internalized by eighteenth-century British subjects in the fashionable “Turquerie” that allowed the wearers to display their wealth by wearing Oriental dress, turbans, ostrich plumes, long capes, veils, and flattering shalvars (figs. 4.9 and 4.10). Another infusion of Orientalism in the West, the tradition of painting European figures in Middle Eastern dress, becomes a form of cultural cross-dressing meant to suggest

misuse of power or excessive wealth (fig. 4.11). Such cultural imports are difficult to be understood, to use Said’s qualification, as expressions of the Occident’s cultural “antipathy”⁸⁴ toward the Orient; rather, they reflect the West’s attraction to a space that connotes difference understood as extraordinariness rather than inferiority.

Besides their connotations of magic, exoticism, and wealth, the things in the *Arabian Nights* are also rich bearers of cultural information: as Marina Warner correctly pointed out, “stories are lodged in goods”⁸⁵ and as such, they expand the reader’s

84 Said, *Orientalism*, 260.

85 Marina Warner, introduction to *Stranger Magic: Charmed States and the Arabian Nights* (London: Chatto & Windus, 2011), 8.